

THEME 7 · B1+/B2

Conflict

7A Coming to Terms — talking about conflicts, giving crucial information, offering solutions

7B Changing Perspectives — looking at conflicts from different points of view

Warm-up

Look at the title: Conflict. What do you think we will talk about in this theme? Tell your partner two ideas.

VOCABULARY

New words

19 target words

conflict

n.



çatışma, anlaşmazlık

The conflict between the two neighbours had been going on for months.

dispute

n.



anlaşmazlık, uyuşmazlık

The dispute over the shared driveway ended up in front of a mediator.

misunderstanding

n.



yanlış anlama

Most of the tension turned out to be a simple misunderstanding.

compromise

n. / v.



uzlaşma, taviz vermek

They reached a compromise: one family kept the tree, the other got a new fence.

mediator

n.



arabulucu

A trained mediator sat down with both neighbours to help them talk calmly.

perspective

n.



bakış açısı, perspektif

Hearing her perspective helped him understand why she had reacted so strongly.

tension

n.



gerginlik

You could feel the tension in the office after the argument.

empathy

n.



empati

Showing empathy, not just logic, often calms a conflict down faster.

apologise

v.



özür dilemek

She finally apologised for interrupting him during the meeting.

common ground

n. phrase



ortak nokta

Even angry neighbours can usually find some common ground.

sort out

phr. v. (transitive)



halletmek, çözmek

They finally sat down to sort out the misunderstanding about the rent.

work out

phr. v. (transitive)



çözüm kavuşturmak

It took two long conversations to work out a fair schedule.

make up

phr. v. (intransitive)



barışmak

The cousins argued for a week, but they made up before the wedding.

fall out

phr. v. (intransitive, + with)



küsmek, ilişkiyi bozmak

The two business partners fell out over money last spring.

stand up for

phr. v. (transitive)



savunmak, arka çıkmak

He stood up for his teammate even though the coach disagreed.

back down

phr. v. (intransitive)



geri adım atmak

Neither side was willing to back down at first.

bring up

phr. v. (transitive)



konuyu açmak, gündeme getirmek

It's risky to bring up money problems at a family dinner.

patch up

phr. v. (transitive)



aralarını düzeltmek

They managed to patch things up before the trip.

come round

phr. v. (intransitive)



fikrini değiştirmek, ikna olmak

He was against the plan at first, but he slowly came round.

Quick game · What's the word?

“çözöme kavuşturmak”

a mediator

b come round

c work out

Quick game · What's the word?

“yanlış anlama”

a misunderstanding

b compromise

c fall out

Quick game · What's the word?

“fkrini deęiřtirmek, ikna olmak”

a conflict

b back down

c come round

Quick game · What's the word?

“aralarını düzeltmek”

a work out

b common ground

c patch up

Quick game · What's the word?

“empati”

a tension

b come round

c empathy

Quick game · What's the word?

“gerginlik”

a perspective

b common ground

c tension

GRAMMAR

Reported Speech: Statements and Questions

Notice

The new intern told her supervisor that she **had already sent** the email twice.

My brother said he **was going to** sort things out with our neighbour that evening.

The counsellor asked the students **if they wanted** to talk about the disagreement.

She asked her colleague **why he hadn't mentioned** the problem earlier.

Which sentences report something someone said (a statement), and which report a question someone asked? What happens to the verb tense and the word order?

Complete the rule

Complete the rule with the words in the box.

backshifts one tense back

if/whether

statement word order (subject + verb)

Complete the rule

In reported speech, the verb generally _____.

✓ **backshifts one tense back**

Complete the rule

Reported yes/no questions use _____ before the subject and verb, with no auxiliary at the front.

✓ if/whether

Complete the rule

**Both reported statements and reported questions use _____ ,
and lose the question mark.**

✓ statement word order (subject + verb)

The rule

In reported speech, the reporting verb (said, told, asked) is usually in the Simple Past, and the tense of the original words backshifts one step: 'I am' → 'was'; 'I did' → 'had done'. In reported questions, we use the question word or if/whether, but keep statement word order (no auxiliary before the subject) and no question mark.

TR Reported speech (aktarılan konuşma) kullanırken, konuşma fiili (said, told, asked) genellikle Simple Past'te olur ve alıntılanan cümledeki fiil bir zaman geriye kayar (backshift): 'I am' → 'was'; 'I did' → 'had done'. Soru cümlelerinde soru sözcüğü ya da if/whether kullanılır, ancak kelime sırası düz bir cümle gibi olur (yardımcı fiil öznenin önce gelmez) ve soru işareti kullanılmaz.

When? We use reported speech to tell someone else what a person said or asked — especially useful for explaining exactly who said what during a disagreement.

TR Birinin ne söylediğini ya da sorduğunu — özellikle bir anlaşmazlık ya da tartışma sırasında kimin ne dediğini — başka birine aktarırken reported speech kullanırız.

Build sentences · Example

Ayşe / say

+

'I / feel / left out'

Ayşe said (that) she felt left out.

Build sentences

the manager / tell / the team + 'we / need / to talk about / this / openly'

The manager told the team (that) they needed to talk about it openly.

Build sentences

Deniz / say + 'I / didn't mean / to upset / anyone'

Deniz said (that) he hadn't meant to upset anyone.

Build sentences

the teacher / ask / the boys

+

'why / are / you / arguing?'

The teacher asked the boys why they were arguing.

Build sentences

Elif / ask / her friend + 'do / you / want / to talk / about it?'

Elif asked her friend if she wanted to talk about it.

Build sentences

? / the mediator / ask / both sides + 'what / would / help / you / most?'

The mediator asked both sides what would help them most.

Your turn

Think of a real or imagined disagreement. Write four sentences reporting what each person said or asked, using reported statements and reported questions.

She told me that...

He said he...

I asked him why...

They asked us if...

Form

POSITIVE

She said (that) she was sorry.

He told me he had already apologised.

NEGATIVE

He said he hadn't meant to shout.

She told us she didn't agree with the decision.

QUESTION

She asked if I was free to talk.

He asked why they hadn't sorted it out sooner.

SHORT ANSWERS

He said he was. / He said he wasn't.

Reported questions have no short answers — restate the full clause instead.

Error detective

She said that she is sorry.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **She said that she was sorry.**

Error detective

He asked did I agree with him.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **He asked if I agreed with him.**

Error detective

She asked me what did I want.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **She asked me what I wanted.**

A • Choose the correct option.

Kaan said that he _____ the message before the meeting.

a hadn't seen

b doesn't see

c isn't seeing

A • Choose the correct option.

The manager asked the team _____ they could meet on Friday instead.

a if

b what

c because

A • Choose the correct option.

She asked me why _____ upset the day before.

a I was

b was I

c I am

B · Complete with the correct form.

He said (that) he _____ (not / mean) to interrupt her.

✓ **hadn't meant**

B · Complete with the correct form.

They asked us _____ we wanted to join the discussion.

✓ if

B · Complete with the correct form.

The teacher asked why the students _____ (argue) again.

✓ **were arguing**

C · Judge the sentence.

She said that she is sorry for the misunderstanding.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **She said that she was sorry for the misunderstanding.**

C · Judge the sentence.

He asked me if I agreed with the plan.

a Correct

b Incorrect

C · Judge the sentence.

The coach asked why did the players stop talking to each other.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **The coach asked why the players had stopped talking to each other.**

Dialogue · Complete with the correct reported form.

A: What did Elif say about the argument? B: She said (that) she _____ (not / want) to fight anymore.

✓ didn't want

Dialogue · Complete with the correct reported form.

A: Did the teacher ask any questions? B: Yes — she asked us why we _____ (not / sort out) it ourselves.

✓ hadn't sorted out

Dialogue · Reorder the sentence.

sorry / said / that / he / truly / he / was

truly

that

he

said

he

sorry

was

•

✓ **He said that he was truly sorry.**

GRAMMAR

First & Second Conditional: Offering Solutions and Advice

Notice

If we **talk** about it honestly, we'll probably find a solution.

If I **were** you, I would apologise before things get worse.

If both sides **listen** to each other, the tension will ease.

If we **had** a mediator, the discussion would be much fairer.

Which sentences describe a realistic condition and its likely result, and which describe a less likely, imagined or advice-giving situation? What verb form follows 'if' in each type?

Complete the rule

Complete the rule with the words in the box.

Simple Present

will + base verb

Past Simple (or 'were')

would + base verb

Complete the rule

**First conditional (a realistic future possibility): If + _____ ,
_____ .**

✓ Simple Present / will + base verb

Complete the rule

Second conditional (an unlikely, imagined situation, or advice with 'If I were you'): If + _____, _____.

✓ Past Simple (or 'were') / would + base verb

The rule

Use the First Conditional for a realistic condition and its likely future result: If + Simple Present, ... will + verb. Use the Second Conditional for a less likely, hypothetical or advice-giving situation: If + Past Simple (usually 'were' for 'be'), ... would + verb. 'If I were you, I would...' is a very common way to give advice.

TR Gerçekleşmesi olası bir durumu ve sonucunu anlatırken First Conditional kullanılır: If + Simple Present, ... will + fiil. Daha az olası, hayali ya da tavsiye niteliğindeki durumlar için Second Conditional kullanılır: If + Past Simple (be fiili için genellikle 'were'), ... would + fiil. 'If I were you, I would...' kalıbı, tavsiye vermenin çok yaygın bir yoludur.

When? We use the First Conditional to offer a realistic solution to a conflict, and the Second Conditional to discuss a hypothetical situation or to give someone advice.

TR Bir anlaşmazlığa gerçekçi bir çözüm önerirken First Conditional; hayali bir durumu tartışırken ya da birine tavsiye verirken Second Conditional kullanırız.

Build sentences · Example

if / they / talk / calmly

+

they / find / a solution

If they talk calmly, they'll find a solution.

Build sentences

if / you / apologise / first

+

she / probably / forgive / you

If you apologise first, she'll probably forgive you.

Build sentences

if / I / be / you + I / not ignore / the problem

If I were you, I wouldn't ignore the problem.

Build sentences

if / both sides / listen / to each other

+

the conflict / calm down

If both sides listen to each other, the conflict will calm down.

Build sentences

if / we / have / a mediator

+

the discussion / be / much fairer

If we had a mediator, the discussion would be much fairer.

Build sentences

? / what / you / do

+

if / your / best friend / stop / talking to you

What would you do if your best friend stopped talking to you?

Your turn

Think of a disagreement (real or invented). Write four conditional sentences offering solutions or advice — use both the first and second conditional.

If they talk about it, ...

If I were them, I would...

If we don't sort this out, ...

What would you do if...?

Form

POSITIVE

If we talk about it, we'll sort it out.

If I were you, I would apologise.

NEGATIVE

If we don't compromise, the tension won't go away.

If she weren't so proud, she wouldn't refuse to talk.

QUESTION

Will they make up if we explain the misunderstanding?

What would you do if you were in this situation?

SHORT ANSWERS

Yes, they probably will. / No, they probably won't.

I would talk to them. / I wouldn't say anything.

Error detective

If we will talk about it, we'll find a solution.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **If we talk about it, we'll find a solution.**

Error detective

If I was you, I would apologise.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **If I were you, I would apologise.**

Error detective

If they listened to each other, they will solve it.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **If they listened to each other, they would solve it.**

A · Choose the correct option.

If both sides _____ calmly, they will probably reach a compromise.

a talk

b talked

c will talk

A • Choose the correct option.

If I _____ you, I would apologise straight away.

a am

b was

c were

A • Choose the correct option.

The tension _____ ease if they stop avoiding each other.

a will

b would

c won't

B · Complete with the correct form.

If we _____ (not / sort out) this soon, it will get worse.

✓ **don't sort out**

B · Complete with the correct form.

If she _____ (have) more patience, she would listen instead of arguing.

✓ had

B · Complete with the correct form.

What _____ you _____ (do) if a friend fell out with you over nothing?

✓ would / do

C · Judge the sentence.

If we will apologise first, they might forgive us.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **If we apologise first, they might forgive us.**

C · Judge the sentence.

If I were you, I would try to see her side of the story.

a Correct

b Incorrect

C · Judge the sentence.

If they listened to each other, they will find common ground.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **If they listened to each other, they would find common ground.**

Dialogue · Complete with the correct conditional form.

A: What would you do _____ (be) in my position?

✓ if you were

Dialogue · Complete with the correct conditional form.

**B: If I _____ (be) you, I _____ (not / ignore) the message —
I'd reply and explain.**

✓ were / wouldn't ignore

Dialogue · Reorder the sentence.

solution / talk / calmly / find / if / a / we / we'll

a

we

find

solution

talk

we'll

if

calmly,

•

✓ **If we talk calmly, we'll find a solution.**

READING

The Fence Between Us

Before you read

1. Look at the title. What kind of conflict do you think this story is about?
2. Have you ever disagreed with a neighbour or classmate about something small that grew into a bigger problem?

THE FENCE BETWEEN US · 1 / 3

When the Aydemirs planted a tall hedge along their garden fence, their neighbours, the Karas, were furious. The hedge blocked the afternoon sun from the Karas' vegetable patch, and within a week the two families were barely speaking. Mr Kara left an angry note; Mrs Aydemir replied with an even angrier one. What had started as a small disagreement over a few metres of greenery was quickly turning into a serious conflict between two families who had once shared coffee every weekend.

THE FENCE BETWEEN US · 2 / 3

Eventually, a mutual friend suggested they invite a local mediator, someone trained to help neighbours sort out exactly this kind of dispute. In their first meeting, the mediator asked each side one simple question: 'What do you actually need, not just what do you want?' It turned out the Karas needed more light for their vegetables, while the Aydemirs needed privacy from a busy street. Once both families understood the other's real reason, the argument suddenly felt much smaller.

THE FENCE BETWEEN US · 3 / 3

The solution wasn't complicated. The Aydemirs agreed to trim the hedge to waist height, keeping their privacy lower down while letting sunlight reach the vegetable patch. Neither family got exactly what they had first demanded, but both got what they truly needed. Six months later, the Karas and Aydemirs were sharing coffee again — and jokes about the infamous hedge.

While you read

What was the real cause of tension between the two families?

a

A disagreement over money

b

A hedge that affected light and privacy

c

A disagreement about a shared car

While you read

The families invited a local _____ to help them talk things through.

✓ mediator

While you read

What question did the mediator ask each side?

a

Who is right and who is wrong?

b

What do you actually need, not just what do you want?

c

Who planted the hedge first?

While you read

According to the text, the Aydemirs completely removed the hedge.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **According to the text, they trimmed the hedge to waist height instead of removing it.**

While you read

Neither family got exactly what they had first demanded, but both got what they truly _____.

✓ needed

After you read

1. Why do you think understanding someone's real 'need' (not just their demand) can help resolve a conflict?
2. Can you think of a compromise that could solve a disagreement you know about?

READING

Two Sides of the Story

Before you read

1. What do you think can cause conflict in a group project at school?
2. Do you think it's fair to judge someone before hearing their side of the story?

TWO SIDES OF THE STORY · 1 / 3

When their teacher put Aslı, Burak and two classmates into a group project on renewable energy, nobody expected it to end in an argument. By the second week, Aslı had written most of the report herself, while Burak had missed two planning meetings without much explanation. 'He clearly doesn't care about the grade,' Aslı complained to her friends, refusing to speak to him directly.

TWO SIDES OF THE STORY · 2 / 3

When their teacher noticed the tension, she asked both students to explain their side privately before deciding anything. Burak admitted he had been working extra shifts at his family's shop after school and had simply lost track of the group's messages. Aslı, meanwhile, admitted she had never actually told him how much extra work she was doing — she had just assumed he knew.

TWO SIDES OF THE STORY · 3 / 3

With their teacher's help, the group redrew the task list, giving Burak a smaller, clearly defined part he could finish around his shifts, and giving Aslı credit for the sections she had already written. Their final presentation on solar energy went smoothly, and afterwards Burak thanked Aslı for not simply reporting him — while Aslı admitted she should have asked, instead of assumed, from the start.

While you read

Why was Aslı frustrated with Burak at first?

a He had copied her work

b He had missed meetings without much explanation

c He had left the group completely

While you read

Burak had been working extra _____ at his family's shop after school.

✓ shifts

While you read

Aslı had clearly told Burak how much extra work she was doing.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ Aslı admitted she had never actually told him — she had just assumed he knew.

While you read

What did the teacher do when she noticed the tension?

a She gave the group a lower grade immediately

b She asked both students to explain their side privately

c She removed Burak from the group

While you read

In the end, the group redrew the _____ so that everyone had a fair, clearly defined part.

✓ **task list**

After you read

1. Why did assuming, instead of asking, make the conflict worse?
2. What would you have done differently if you were Aslı, from the start?

LISTENING

Sorting It Out

Before you listen

1. Predict: what kind of everyday disagreement do you think Zeynep and her flatmate had?

Sorting It Out

Ses kaydı yakında — transkripti öğretmen okuyabilir.

While you listen

What was the argument between Zeynep and Selin about?

a Money

b The cleaning schedule

c A university assignment

While you listen

This morning, Selin asked if they could talk _____ instead of shouting.

✓ calmly

While you listen

Zeynep believes making a proper rota might stop the arguments.

a Correct

b Incorrect

While you listen

What does Zeynep suggest if the rota doesn't work?

a Moving out

b Asking their third
flatmate to be a
mediator

c Ignoring the problem

LISTENING

Peer Mediators at Our School

Before you listen

1. What do you predict a 'peer mediator' does at school?

Peer Mediators at Our School

Ses kaydı yakında — transkripti öğretmen okuyabilir.

While you listen

What is a peer mediator?

a

A teacher who punishes students

b

A trained student who helps classmates sort out small conflicts

c

A school counsellor

While you listen

The mediator asks each person to explain their side and listen without _____.

✓ interrupting

While you listen

According to Mira, the mediator decides who is right and who is wrong.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ According to Mira, the mediator doesn't decide who's right — they help both sides listen to each other.

While you listen

According to Mira, what happens to serious problems?

a They are ignored

b They still go to a teacher

c They are handled only by mediators

SPEAKING

Take Sides or Find Middle Ground?

In pairs, discuss a short conflict scenario your teacher gives you (e.g. two classmates disagree about a shared project, or two neighbours argue about noise). Use reported speech to explain what each side said, and conditionals to suggest a solution.

SPEAKING

A Conflict I Helped Solve (or Wish I Had)

Prepare a two-minute talk about a real or invented conflict — between friends, family members, classmates or colleagues. Explain what happened, what each side wanted, and how it was (or could be) resolved.

WRITING

Sorting It Out: A Conflict Story

Write a short narrative about a conflict (real or invented) between two people. Describe what caused the disagreement, what each side said or felt, and how it was eventually resolved. Use at least one example of reported speech.

WRITING

How Would You Solve It? An Advice Text

A reader has written to an advice column about a conflict with a friend, neighbour or colleague. Write a reply offering practical solutions, using first and second conditional sentences ('If you..., you'll...' / 'If I were you, I'd...').

REVIEW

Exit ticket

Exit ticket

After the meeting, the two colleagues finally managed to
_____ their disagreement.

a sort out

b show off

c catch on

Exit ticket

If both sides _____ to each other, they will probably find a compromise.

a listen

b listened

c will listen

Exit ticket

If I _____ (be) you, I would apologise before it gets worse.

✓ were

Exit ticket

She said that she _____ (not / mean) to upset anyone.

✓ **hadn't meant**

Exit ticket

A neutral person who helps two sides reach an agreement is called a _____ .

a mediator

b thrill-seeker

c wrestler

Exit ticket

The two neighbours finally stopped arguing and started to find some _____ .

✓ common ground

Exit ticket

He asked me did I agree with the plan.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **He asked me if I agreed with the plan.**

Exit ticket

If we will talk about it honestly, we'll find a solution.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **If we talk about it honestly, we'll find a solution.**

Exit ticket

cousins / eventually / the / two / up / made

two

cousins

made

the

eventually

up

•

✓ **The two cousins eventually made up.**

Exit ticket

Rewrite using reported speech.

("I didn't take your notes," Mert said. (Mert said...))

✓ **Mert said (that) he hadn't taken her notes.**

Exit ticket

Which sentence best reports a question?

a She asked if I was busy.

b She asked was I busy.

c She asked that I am busy.

Exit ticket

The manager asked the team why they _____ (argue) again.

✓ were arguing

Exit ticket

According to Reading 1, the two families never spoke again after the hedge argument.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **According to the text, they were sharing coffee again six months later.**